



ANIARA

The Doors to the Stars

*freely inspired by Harry Martinson's epic poem,
infused with Strindbergian Dream Play-logic*

A theatrical work in five movements
with ritual interludes and dream-logic

by

Eko Svenningsson aka ECHOx

an ECHOxPRODUCTION

ANIARA: The Doors to the Stars

© Eko Svenningsson aka ECHOx — All rights reserved.

Rights, performance permissions, and inquiries:
inbox@echoxstudios.art

PART I: INTRODUCTION

Overview

ANIARA: The Doors to the Stars is a poetic, richly layered, and theatrically audacious reimagining of Harry Martinson's epic poem. This is not a conventional adaptation—it is a metaphysical echo rendered through ritual, movement, and dream.

Drawing on the lyrical resonance of Martinson and the surreal structure of Strindberg's *A Dream Play*, the play unfolds like memory itself: fragmented, recursive, haunted. It is a meditation on drift, exile, and the human spirit fractured by loss.

This is not a sci-fi spectacle. It is a lament. A dream. A requiem for Earth.

The story unfolds aboard the Aniara, a spacecraft lost irreversibly in deep space. Once bound for Mars, now unmoored, it becomes an ark with no arrival. At its heart is the Mima—an archive system designed to hold all of human memory. But when she is turned to for comfort instead of data, she begins to break.

As she unravels, so too does everything else: time, order, purpose, self.

The structure of the play mirrors the ship's descent—from precision into myth, from system into ritual, from future into dream.

Yet within the unraveling, there are ruptures—breaches into dream-state and longing. The passengers slip through moments of trance, intimacy, absurdity. At the height of collapse, Doris appears—not as character, but as memory's echo in motion. Earth dances once more.

At the end, there is no epilogue. Just a Door. And one last ritual. A toy car crosses the stage. The pilot watches.

This is not merely to be performed. It is to be inhabited.

Two full pauses are integrated into the performance. In the foyer, strange machines whisper. In Pause One, a sealed metal door appears—silent, humming. In Pause Two, the door stands

wide open. Close it, and it opens again. The broken STAMP CLOCK has returned, printing strange slips and whispering fractured announcements.

This is where identity begins to blur. Where order gives way to chaos.

Who are you now?

Dramaturgical Movements

The journey unfolds in five major movements—shifts not only in plot, but in tone, form, and consciousness. Five ruptural, decimal-marked scenes (5.5, 6.25, 6.5, 8.5, 8.75) intervene as breaches—poetic breathwork, tonal deviations that break rhythm and allow intimacy, absurdity, and myth to intrude.

Launch (Order)

We begin in symmetry. The ship lifts. All is tracked, calculated, controlled. The Mima hums. The Earth is gone. A new world is promised.

Scene 1: Boarding and liftoff. Passengers carry Earth's soil in sealed glass.

Scene 2: Orientation. The STAMP CLOCK is introduced. Mima is archive, not oracle.

Disorientation (The Drift Begins)

A deviation. Something has changed. The course bends. The stars twist. Unregistered doors appear. The illusion of safety falters.

Scene 3: A course correction. A jolt. Doubts spread.

Scene 4: A forced briefing. The truth is withheld. The Mima begins to shudder.

— **First Pause** —

In the foyer: a metal door has appeared. It hums softly. It will not open.

Fracture (Dream Logic Emerges)

Grief becomes communal. Dreams infect reality. The Mima begins to echo what no one dares say. The Captain prepares to tell the truth.

Scene 5: Testimonies of loss. Doors remembered. Names spoken in dust.

Scene 5.5: The Shadow Patrol. Chefone walks his rounds, encountering Lyreah in the darkness. A conversation about loss, duty, and the weight of protocol reveals the human cost of order.

Scene 6: Diagnostics. System strain. The Captain requests solitude—to record the message.

Scene 6.25: The Mima Immersion. Passengers seek comfort in the archive, but the Mima shows them the Flash—the collective trauma they’ve tried to forget. Cult factions begin to form.

Scene 6.5: “Have You Ever Fucked a Ghost?” The Bar opens. Mirabelle and Lior meet without mask. Intimacy, laughter, drink, and a whispered theory of God. Alune disrupts.

Unraveling (Collapse of Structure)

The truth is broadcast. There is no Mars. No return. Screams rise like hymns. Identity begins to blur. Lyreah becomes the Blind Seer.

Scene 7: Communiqué du Dérive. The passengers erupt in a ghostly chorus.

Scene 8: The Ark of Dark. Mima breaks. The world becomes vision. Time loses form.

Scene 8.5: Corridor Spliff. Kristina and Thale find an unmapped corridor. They share a joint and speak of memory, burning stars, and small truths in drifting spaces. A quiet counterpoint to collapse.

Scene 8.75: Dorisvale Revisited, or The Mima Dream. A dream-ritual in the Mima core. Doors, masks, mirrors, toy cars, manets, and memory collide. Doris appears— Earth remembered in grace—and vanishes. Grief remains.

— Second Pause —

In the foyer: the same door is now wide open. If closed—it opens again. The STAMP CLOCK is alive. It prints fragments.

Passage (Beyond)

Mima dies. Cults arise. Order collapses. A new Door appears. A funeral for Mima is held. One by one, the passengers pass through the final door. What lies beyond is unknowable—and still, they go.

Scene 9: The Funeral for Mima. The crew mourns their lost archive. The Mima’s death is fully acknowledged.

Scene 10: Rites of Collapse. The Cults of Mima, Flesh, and Order perform their final rites. The last Door. Lyreah speaks from beyond. The passengers vanish. The toy car rolls. The Pilot watches. The play ends.

Cast and Character Constellation

Total Cast Size: Estimated 12–15 performers. (Minimum 11 with strategic doubling, maximum 18 for full chorus and dance integration.)

This production is built for flexibility in scale. Through doubling and modular staging, a relatively small ensemble can evoke a vast emotional and symbolic landscape. Chorus performers support principal roles through ritual, transformation, and voice.

Primary Ship Crew (5 Roles)

- **The Mimarobe—The Empath:** Keeper of the Mima, she absorbs the passengers' memories and grief. Poetic, intuitive, and ultimately destabilized by sorrow.
- **The Captain—The Pillar:** Charismatic and grave. Holds authority but suffers under its weight. Speaks the truth when it costs everything.
- **Chefone (Chief of Security)—The Order:** Harsh but sincere. Believes in structure at all cost. Later becomes an enforcer of the Cult of Order.
- **Ensel (Chief Operations Officer)—The Skeptic-Pathfinder:** Technically grounded, emotionally withdrawn. Handles both ship systems and navigation. The last to believe in visions, the first to name what breaks. Gentle and analytical, tracks stellar data as it begins to unravel.
- **Mirabelle (Science Officer)—The Diagnostic:** Dry, methodical, scientific. Explains what can be measured, fears what cannot.
- **The Pilot—The Destiny:** Silent figure. Endures. Never leaves the helm. A symbol of constancy amid drift.

The Passengers (5 Roles)

- **Kristina (Passenger 1)—The Soil-Bearer:** Earth-rooted, ceremonial. Carries the last of Earth's soil. Speaks in metaphors of seed and death.
- **Thale (Passenger 2)—The Living Memory:** Fragile and obsessed with remembering names. Vulnerable to collapse.
- **Lyreah (Passenger 3)—The Blind Poetess □ The Blind Seer:** Poetic visionary. Transforms during the play's collapse, becoming the metaphysical voice of the play's end.
- **Lior (Passenger 4)—The Sublime Presence:** Mystical and strange. Their lines border on prophecy.
- **Alune (Passenger 5)—The Beast Within:** Marked by guilt and trauma. Central in the Cult of Flesh.

Doris (1 Dance Role)

- **Doris—The Earth Remembered:** She is not a speaker, but a mover. A classical ballet dancer. Doris is Earth’s dream of herself—embodied in grace, harmony, and unreachable beauty. She only appears in Scene 8.75, but her impact reverberates through the play’s most finite movements. This role is to be cast with a professional dancer, not a classical actor.

The Chorus (Flexible, 2–6 Performers)

A shape-shifting presence. Chorus members double as cultists, crew, clowns, passengers, and memory-beings. Their movement and voice structure ritual scenes and emotional texture. They do not speak as individuals, but as atmosphere, echo, and collective embodiment. Often masked. Always essential.

Copyright and Source Acknowledgement

ANIARA: The Doors to the Stars is a transformative dramatic work, freely and respectfully inspired by Harry Martinson’s 1956 epic poem *Aniara: en revy om människan i tid och rum*.

Originally composed in Swedish, Martinson’s *Aniara* remains, in essence, a linguistically and poetically untranslated masterpiece. Its sonic textures, philosophical depth, and surreal structure resist conventional adaptation and demand artistic interpretation rather than replication.

In 1974, Martinson was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature, with *Aniara* recognized as a monumental work in the modern literary canon. His vision blends science fiction, metaphysics, and lyrical lament into a singular, genre-defying achievement.

This stage production does not attempt to quote, translate, or stage the original poem. Instead, it echoes its spirit through a wholly new theatrical form—infused with dream-logic, original characters, invented scenes, and a poetic structure modeled on the rhythm and tone of the Swedish source.

All stage directions, dialogue, poetry, and dramaturgical architecture are the original creative work of Eko Svenningsson (aka ECHOx).

This adaptation is to be understood as a freestanding theatrical piece in artistic conversation with its source. It honors the themes and atmosphere of Martinson’s poem while stepping into new expressive terrain. All performances, publications, or citations must credit both the original inspiration and the distinct authorship of this work.

For rights inquiries or performance permissions, please contact the author through inbox@echoxstudios.art.

Why Is This Relevant?

In 1956, Harry Martinson looked toward the stars and saw not salvation—but sorrow. *Aniara* was his warning: a poetic vision of humanity adrift, both spiritually and cosmically, exiled from the Earth it could not save.

Nearly eight decades later, that vision feels less speculative than prophetic.

Artificial intelligence now dreams on our behalf. Ecosystems fracture. Identity itself becomes fluid in the wake of planetary collapse. We are, quite literally, drifting—socially, spiritually, technologically. The questions Martinson posed in metaphor are now lived realities:

- What does it mean to be human beyond Earth?
- What remains of us when memory detaches from soil, water, gravity?
- Can culture survive dislocation? Can meaning survive exile?

ANIARA: The Doors to the Stars does not attempt to answer these questions. It enacts them. It makes space for the audience to feel them—to grieve, reflect, and imagine.

It is not science fiction. It is myth. It is ritual. It is theatre as invocation and echo.

It reminds us that the great drift we fear is not only across stars—but within ourselves.

*We are the passengers now.
We are the memory that must not break.*

We are the ones who choose whether to walk through the door.

PART II: ACT I - LAUNCH &



DISORIENTATION

Scene One: Launch Sequence

Cold, white light. The boarding hall. A vast and gleaming space. Passengers wait in quiet ranks. They hold their soil in sealed glass cubes—small tombs of Earth. The sound of systems hums beneath the floor, a pulse that matches no one's heart. Enter Mimarobe and Chefone.

CHEFONE

Prepare for launch. All sectors clear.
Zone Four advance. Zone Five, stand near.
No lag. No doubt. No fear. Proceed.
We are the flame. The spark. The seed.

MIMAROBÉ

We leave a world that could not hold.
We flee its ash, its shattered gold.
Yet each of us, in silence, brings
a weight of lost and burning things.

Kristina steps forward with a cube of soil.

KRISTINA

This earth is from my mother's field—
where apples grew, and time could yield.
Will it take root on Mars, and live?
Can cold red ground learn how to give?

CHEFONE

If moisture, light, and heat are right—
then growth is well within our sight.

KRISTINA

Within our sight,
you say.
Then I will trust.
Although we lift—we go—because we must.

She steps onward. Others follow, each carrying their glass cubes of soil like sacred relics.

MIMAROBÉ

Three feet of earth.
That's all we keep.
Three feet to sow, to dream, to sleep.
What gods we were, and what remains:
some dust,
some names,
some windowpanes.

Enter Ensel and Lyreah from opposite sides of the space.

ENSEL

The instruments spin, misaligned.
Twitches. Veers.
The mimatrons hum, but not in the right spheres.
I am worried over our journey's course.
Something eerie pulls with force.

LYREAH (The Blind Poetess)

The stars are worrisome. They always were.
They burn like lies. They hum and blur.
Just breathe. Just wait. Just trust the sound.
One thing is sure, we will rise—
and float away from ground.

CHEFONE

Enough. The course is set.
No more.
We lift at zero-one-two-four.
What drifts in mind must not infect

the order we are sworn to protect.

The launch begins. A low rumble builds beneath their feet. The ship shudders once, twice, then lifts with gathering force. The last voice is Mimarobe's.

MIMAROBÉ

So now we lift.

From soil. From sun.

From every field where dreams have run.

From Doris' hills. From broken seas.

We rise into
unending freeze.

The lights fade to black as the ship departs Earth forever.

Scene Two: Orientation

First afternoon aboard. A clean-lit corridor hums with low mechanical rhythm. The passengers are assembled for their initial briefing. Captain stands before them, authoritative yet warm. Chefone and Mimarobe flank him. A wall-unit glows dimly: the STAMP CLOCK.

CAPTAIN

You've passed through fire. You've left the flood.

The world behind is ash and mud.

But here, aboard, we do not mourn.

This vessel is a world reborn.

Its frame is clean. Its arc is true.

It learns your needs. It watches you.

The Clock will mark each soul and day—
its voice is order, not dismay.

CHEFONE

No chaos here. No broken thread.

No dream denied. No hunger bred.

Just stamp your card. The gate will read.

You'll gain your rest. You'll take your feed.

CAPTAIN

And this, the Mimarobe. She tends
the vault where memory never ends.

She keeps what Earth can't hold in place—
a breath, a song, a vanished face.

He nods toward Mimarobe. She steps forward, humble yet commanding.

MIMAROBÉ

I govern Mima, but her nerves I do not steer.
She holds what once was rooted—near.
Not only to preserve—but to prepare.
We must recall, if we would dare.

To plant a future, clean and true,
we first must know what broke it through.
Mima holds the shape we left behind—
not as a cage, but as a mind.

The STAMP CLOCK is activated. A passenger steps forward. A tone sounds. A slip is printed and taken. Another follows.

THALE

That's it? A stamp? No test? No code?
Just scan and pass? No structured load?

CAPTAIN

A tiny act—but not in vain.
The system tracks through joy and strain.
Each breath you take, each route you trace—
it marks the tempo of this place.

And if it seems too small a thing,
consider what small things can bring.
This ship will hold through dust and sky—
not by command, but by AI.

They proceed now toward the Mima chamber. The lights dim slightly. A low harmonic hum rises. Mimarobe stands before a great sealed door, her hand resting on its surface.

MIMAROBÉ

This is her chamber. Warm. Profound.
The echo vault, the memory ground.
She doesn't judge, or dream, or lie—
she simply keeps what must not die.

Each ship must hold a house, a place for this.
By law, by ethic—not by bliss.
The smell of rain, a child's cry,
a field beneath a summer sky.

ALUNE

But why recall what's long decayed?
Why mourn the ghosts that should have stayed?

KRISTINA

Because what's buried still has root.
And memory, like seed, takes fruit.

LYREAH (The Blind Poetess)

We're headed forward. We're not blind.
Why feed the ache we left behind?

MIMAROBÉ

The past we bring, so we can glue—
a future—whole and true.
Nothing to fear. No tricks. Just our collective dreams.
Each and every whisper, caught in silent streams.
Come. Try. It's free. It doesn't bite.
It only glows in willing light.

Thale steps forward, places a hand to the console. Silence. Then breath. Then voice.

THALE

It is true!—
I felt the tide. I smelled the pine.
A door. A breeze. A voice like mine.
It wasn't sharp, or full, or bright.
But it was real. And it was right.

LIOR

It's touching, sure. But we move on.
What's past is mist. We need forgive!
—What's done is gone.

CHEFONE

Enough. The purpose has been shown.
She holds the dead. And we atone.
You stamp. You eat. You move in time.
And all proceeds within the line.

The crowd disperses slowly. One passenger lingers at the Mima console. Mimarobe stays, watching. She almost whispers.

MIMAROBÉ

She's neither stone, nor ash.
She carries the ember past the flash.
She does not change—but she will know
the moment we begin to go.

Blackout.

Scene Three: The Disruption

A low-frequency tone rises from deep within the ship. The vessel shudders—once, then again. Lights flicker. A brief silence. Then voices. Alarms do not sound—but something deeper has shifted. Emergency lights steady to a dim amber glow. Captain's voice crackles through the comm system.

CAPTAIN (voice only)

Remain in place. Remain in calm.
The systems hold. There is no harm.
A fluctuation. Nothing more.
Return to duty. Check the floor.

But already, passengers have gathered in quiet panic in the Central Hall. Mimarobe watches from the margin, her hand pressed to the wall as if listening to the ship's pulse. Chefone enters briskly, checking his tablet. Then the Captain appears, flanked by his officers.

CAPTAIN

This gathering, though sudden, is meant to inform.
Ensel, Mirabelle—please brief the swarm.

ENSEL

We passed a belt—uncharted, dense.
Its pull unstitched both course and sense.
The arc we flew unraveled, bent.
Our plotted line came—and went.
Navigation systems show severe drift.
Our stellar reference points have shifted.

End of sample.

The complete script is available to producers, directors and programmers on request.

inbox@echoxstudios.art